

I would first like to start with a short note that I enjoyed the speeches of both Aristophanes and Phaedrus, however since I'm guessing many of the classmates will be writing about Aristophanes I will write about Phaedrus.

For starters, Phaedrus' speech takes place on pages 117 to 120 beginning with Eros being a very great god among gods due to the fact that Eros (according to Phaedrus) was one of the primordial gods, one of the very first gods to be brought into existence, and one without parents. This I believe contradicts later tellings of greek mythology where Eros is the son of Aphrodite (or in roman god terms Cupid [Eros] is the son of Venus [Aphrodite]) but it appears that Phaedrus is very keen on Eros being a primordial god and this not being a debated topic in mythology. Phaedrus argues that since Eros is a primordial god, he is one that brings some of the greatest goods to mankind, namely the ambition for finding a worthy lover and to be a worthy beloved. Phaedrus argues that one would never wish to be seen as shameful in front of their lover and believes that "men of this sort would be victorious even if they were but few against a nearly all mankind. For a man in love would surely not let himself be seen by his beloved, beyond all others, deserting his post or throwing down his arms; he would choose to die many times before that"¹. Infact, this idea of death is quite pronounced in Phaedrus' speech as he argues that only lovers are willing to die on behalf of one another. Phaedrus then recalls a myth of Alcestis who dies on behalf of her husband to prove to the gods that she truly loves him. Phaedrus then argues that since the parents of the husband didn't die for their son that Alcestis made them look like strangers to him. Similarly, Phaedrus argues that Orpheus didnt truly love Eurydice (or rather he didn't love her to the highest degree) because instead of Orpheus killing himself he traveled to the Place of the Dead in order to bring them both back alive. Phaedrus then wraps up with a story of Achilles dying for Patroclus and arguing that Eros is a very respected and authoritative good with respect to virtue and happiness for both the living and the dead.

Thus the overall claim of Phaedrus' speech is that since Eros is one of the oldest gods he is in charge of one of the greatest goods. The logical structure of his speech I believe to be fairly straightforward in that he first outlines the first part of his statement (that Eros is one of the oldest gods) and backs it up with evidence of the poets agreeing with his point. He then writes about the second part of his claim, that is Eros is in responsible for some of the greatest goods, using mythological stories as evidence (Alcestis, Orpheus, and Achilles). Now since Phaedrus was the first person to give the speech after Eryximachus suggested everyone gives a short speech on Eros, Phaedrus is creating the foundation for the remaining speeches that love and Eros is a very strong force for the greeks and society.

¹Plato, "The Symposium," in *The Dialogues of Plato*, (Yale University Press), 118.